CSE 4106: Computer Networks Laboratory

EMTP: Enhanced Mail Transfer Protocol with Priority-based Delivery and End-to-End Encryption

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Contents

Objectives **1**

1 Introduction **1**
1.1 Simple Mail Transfer Protocol (SMTP) 1
1.2 RSA Encryption Fundamentals 2
1.3 Priority Queuing and Quality of Service 2
1.4 Application-Layer Filtering 3

2 Methodology **3**
2.1 Network Architecture Design 3
2.2 SMTP Protocol State Machine 4
2.3 RSA Encryption Algorithm 4
2.4 Priority Queue Management 6
2.5 Application-Layer Filtering 6

3 Implementation **7**
3.1 OMNeT++ Simulation Framework 7
3.1.1 Message Definitions (SMTPMessage.msg) 8
3.1.2 Encryption Module (EncryptionHelper.h/.cc) 8
3.1.3 Client Module (ClientModule.ned/.h/.cc) 9
3.1.4 Server Module (ServerModule.ned/.h/.cc) 9
3.2 Network Topology Definition (EMTPNetwork.ned) 9
3.3 Simulation Configurations 10
3.4 Collected Metrics 10

4 Discussion **11**
4.1 Baseline vs Constrained Performance 11
4.2 Encryption Overhead Analysis 11
4.3 Protocol Correctness Verification 12

5 Conclusion **12**

Bibliography **13**

List of Figures

1 SMTP client-server communication model 2
2 Priority queue scheduling mechanisms 2
3 EMTP network topology with star configuration 3
4 Client SMTP state machine 4

List of Tables

1 Network Component Specifications 4
2 Simulation Scenario Configurations 10
3 Baseline Scenario Expected Results 11
4 Constrained Scenario Expected Results 11
5 Encryption Overhead Comparison 11

Objectives

- To design and implement a complete SMTP (Simple Mail Transfer Protocol) simulation demonstrating the standard client-server mail transfer flow using OMNeT++ discrete event simulator.
- To extend the basic SMTP protocol with end-to-end RSA encryption at the application layer, enabling secure message transmission between clients and server.
- To implement a priority-based mail delivery system with separate HIGH and LOW priority queues, demonstrating Quality of Service (QoS) differentiation in email systems.
- To develop application-layer mail filtering mechanisms that validate message headers, enforce encryption policies, and reject invalid emails before queuing.
- To evaluate system performance across six distinct scenarios including baseline operation, constrained resources, encryption overhead, filtering effectiveness, high load, and single client verification.
- To analyze the trade-offs between priority-based scheduling and fair queuing through statistical metrics including delivery latency, queue sizes, and acceptance rates.

1 Introduction

Email communication remains one of the most critical applications in modern computer networks. The Simple Mail Transfer Protocol (SMTP) serves as the standard for email transmission, defining a client-server interaction model for reliable message delivery. This project implements an Enhanced Mail Transfer Protocol (EMTP) simulation that extends SMTP with advanced features addressing contemporary security and quality of service requirements.

1.1 Simple Mail Transfer Protocol (SMTP)

SMTP, defined in RFC 5321, is an application-layer protocol operating over TCP port 25. The protocol follows a command-response model where clients issue text-based commands and servers respond with numeric status codes. The standard SMTP transaction consists of five essential commands:

- **HELO/EHLO**: Initiates the session by identifying the client to the server
- **MAIL FROM**: Specifies the sender's email address
- **RCPT TO**: Specifies the recipient's email address
- **DATA**: Transmits the email content including headers and body
- **QUIT**: Terminates the session gracefully

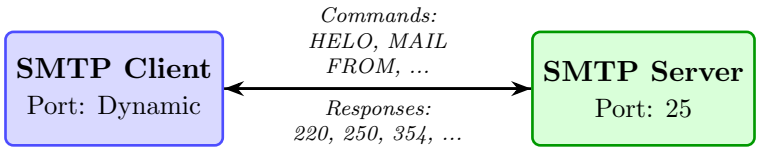

Figure 1: SMTP client-server communication model

The server responds with three-digit status codes: 2xx for success, 3xx for intermediate states, 4xx for transient errors, and 5xx for permanent failures. This simple yet robust protocol has powered email communication for decades.

1.2 RSA Encryption Fundamentals

RSA (Rivest-Shamir-Adleman) is an asymmetric encryption algorithm that uses a public-private key pair. The security relies on the computational difficulty of factoring large prime numbers. Key generation involves:

1. Select two distinct prime numbers: p and q
2. Compute the modulus: $n = p \times q$
3. Calculate Euler's totient: $\phi(n) = (p-1)(q-1)$
4. Choose public exponent e where $1 < e < \phi(n)$ and $\gcd(e, \phi(n)) = 1$
5. Compute private exponent: $d \equiv e^{-1} \pmod{\phi(n)}$

Encryption and decryption operations:

$$Ciphertext = Plaintext^e \bmod n \tag{1}$$

$$Plaintext = Ciphertext^d \bmod n \tag{2}$$

The public key (e, n) can be freely distributed while the private key (d, n) must remain secret. This enables secure communication where anyone can encrypt messages but only the key holder can decrypt them.

1.3 Priority Queuing and Quality of Service

Priority queuing is a scheduling mechanism that assigns different service levels to packets or messages based on importance. In mail systems, priority affects delivery latency when resources are constrained.

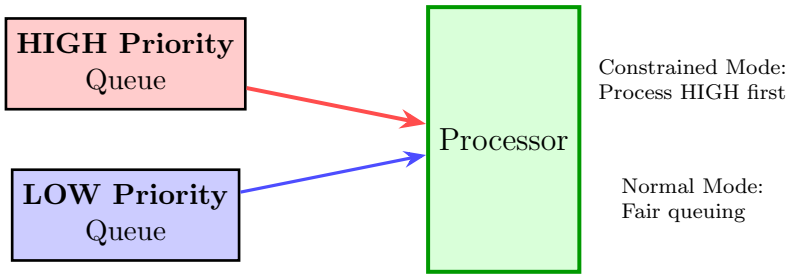

Figure 2: Priority queue scheduling mechanisms

Two common approaches are:

Fair Queuing: Services all queues equally, providing similar latencies regardless of priority.

Strict Priority: Always services the highest priority queue first. Lower priority traffic only processed when higher queues are empty.

The trade-off involves balancing quality of service differentiation against potential starvation of low-priority traffic.

1.4 Application-Layer Filtering

Application-layer filtering examines message content and headers to enforce security policies. Unlike network-layer firewalls that inspect IP/port information, application-layer filters understand protocol semantics and can validate:

- Message structure and required headers
- Content validity and format compliance
- Encryption and authentication credentials
- Business logic rules specific to the application

This deep inspection enables more sophisticated security policies but requires protocol-specific implementation for each application.

2 Methodology

2.1 Network Architecture Design

The EMTP simulation implements a star topology with multiple clients connected to a central server through dedicated channels. This architecture reflects typical email infrastructure where clients connect to their mail server for message submission.

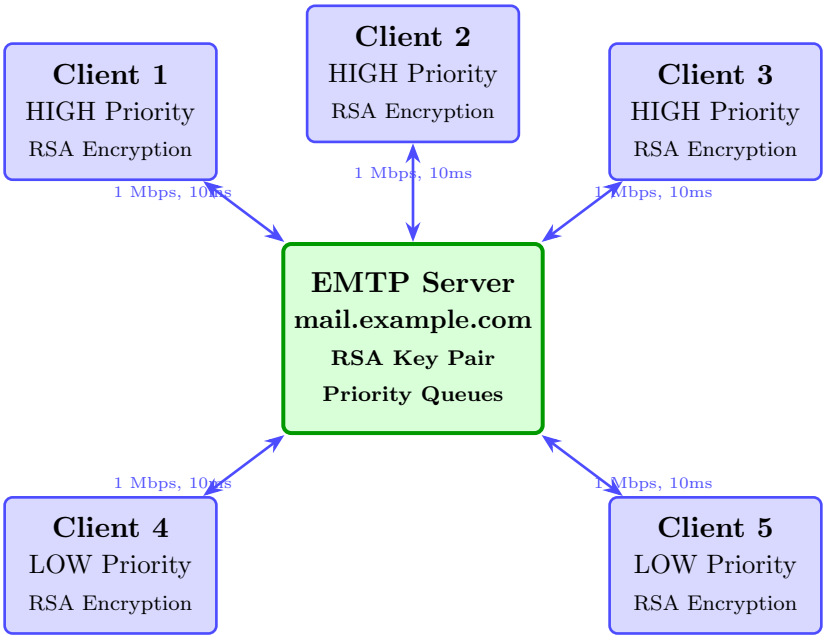

Figure 3: EMTP network topology with star configuration

Table 1: Network Component Specifications

Component	Type	Function
ClientModule	Simple Module	Initiates SMTP sessions, encrypts messages, sends emails with priority
ServerModule	Simple Module	Processes SMTP commands, decrypts messages, manages priority queues, filters content
Channel	DatarateChannel	Bidirectional link with 1 Mbps bandwidth and 10ms propagation delay

2.2 SMTP Protocol State Machine

The client implements a finite state machine that sequences SMTP commands in the correct order. Each state waits for the appropriate server response before transitioning.

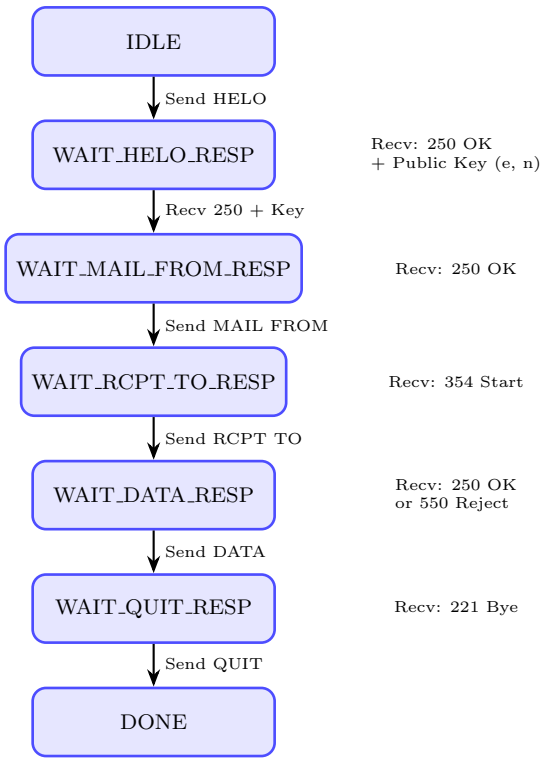

Figure 4: Client SMTP state machine

The server maintains connection state and validates command sequencing, rejecting out-of-order commands with error codes.

2.3 RSA Encryption Algorithm

The encryption process operates character-by-character for simplicity in simulation. While not suitable for production, this approach clearly demonstrates asymmetric encryption principles.

Algorithm 1 RSA Key Generation

```
function GenerateKeyPair(seed)
    p ← GeneratePrime(seed)                          ▷ First prime: 251-367
    q ← GeneratePrime(seed + 100)                    ▷ Second prime
    n ← p × q                                        ▷ Modulus
    φ ← (p − 1) × (q − 1)                            ▷ Euler's totient
    e ← 65537                                        ▷ Standard public exponent
    if e ≥ φ then
        e ← e mod φ
    end if
    while gcd(e, φ) ≠ 1 do
        e ← e + 2
    end while
    d ← ModInverse(e, φ)                             ▷ Private exponent
    return (e, n, d)                                 ▷ Public: (e,n), Private: (d,n)
end function
```

Algorithm 2 Message Encryption and Decryption

```
function Encrypt(plaintext, e, n)
    ciphertext ← ""
    for each character c in plaintext do
        m ← ASCII(c)
        encrypted ← m^e mod n                        ▷ Modular exponentiation
        ciphertext ← ciphertext + encrypted + ","
    end for
    return ciphertext
end function

function Decrypt(ciphertext, d, n)
    plaintext ← ""
    Split ciphertext by commas into array values
    for each value in values do
        decrypted ← value^d mod n                    ▷ Modular exponentiation
        plaintext ← plaintext + char(decrypted)
    end for
    return plaintext
end function
```

Modular exponentiation is computed efficiently using the square-and-multiply algorithm:

$$a^b \bmod m = \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if } b = 0 \\ (a^{b/2} \bmod m)^2 \bmod m & \text{if } b \text{ even} \\ a \times (a^{b-1} \bmod m) \bmod m & \text{if } b \text{ odd} \end{cases} \tag{3}$$

2.4 Priority Queue Management

The server maintains separate queues for HIGH and LOW priority mails. Processing behavior depends on the operational mode.

Algorithm 3 Priority-Based Queue Processing

```
function ProcessDeliveryQueue
    if constrainedMode = true then
                                        ▷ Strict priority: Always process HIGH first
        if highPriorityQueue not empty then
            mail ← DequeueFrom(highPriorityQueue)
        else if lowPriorityQueue not empty then
            mail ← DequeueFrom(lowPriorityQueue)
        else
            return                                          ▷ Both queues empty
        end if
    else
                                        ▷ Fair queuing: Alternate between queues
        if lastProcessedHigh and lowPriorityQueue not empty then
            mail ← DequeueFrom(lowPriorityQueue)
            lastProcessedHigh ← false
        else if highPriorityQueue not empty then
            mail ← DequeueFrom(highPriorityQueue)
            lastProcessedHigh ← true
        else if lowPriorityQueue not empty then
            mail ← DequeueFrom(lowPriorityQueue)
        else
            return
        end if
    end if
    DeliverMail(mail)
    RecordStatistics(mail)
    Schedule next delivery after deliveryRate
end function
```

Expected latency characteristics:

$$Latency_{HIGH,normal} \approx Latency_{LOW,normal} \tag{4}$$

$$Latency_{HIGH,constrained} \ll Latency_{LOW,constrained} \tag{5}$$

2.5 Application-Layer Filtering

Before accepting mail into the queue, the server applies validation rules to ensure message validity and policy compliance.

Algorithm 4 Mail Filtering and Validation

```
function FilterMail(mailData)
                                                    ▷ Check encryption requirement
    if requireEncryption and not mailData.isEncrypted then
        return REJECT("Encryption required")
    end if

                                                    ▷ Decrypt if encrypted
    if mailData.isEncrypted then
        decryptedBody ← Decrypt(mailData.encryptedBody)
        if decryptedBody is empty or invalid then
            return REJECT("Decryption failed")
        end if
    else
        decryptedBody ← mailData.encryptedBody
    end if

                                                    ▷ Validate required fields
    if requireSubject and mailData.subject is empty then
        return REJECT("Subject required")
    end if

    if decryptedBody is empty then
        return REJECT("Empty message body")
    end if

                                                    ▷ Validate priority
    if mailData.priority ∉ {HIGH, LOW} then
        return REJECT("Invalid priority")
    end if

                                                    ▷ Check queue capacity
    if totalQueueSize ≥ maxQueueSize then
        return REJECT("Queue full")
    end if

    return ACCEPT(decryptedBody)
end function
```

3 Implementation

3.1 OMNeT++ Simulation Framework

The project is implemented using OMNeT++ 6.0, a modular discrete event simulator designed for communication networks. The implementation consists of four primary file types working together to create a complete simulation environment.

3.1.1 Message Definitions (SMTPMessage.msg)

Protocol messages are defined using OMNeT++'s message description language, which generates corresponding C++ classes:

```
enum SMTPCommandType {
    CMD_HELO = 1;        // Initiate session
    CMD_MAIL_FROM = 2;   // Specify sender
    CMD_RCPT_TO = 3;     // Specify recipient
    CMD_DATA = 4;        // Send message content
    CMD_QUIT = 5;        // Terminate session
}

enum MailPriority {
    PRIORITY_LOW = 0;    // Low priority mail
    PRIORITY_HIGH = 1;   // High priority mail
}

packet MailData extends SMTPMessage {
    string sender;
    string recipient;
    string subject;
    int priority @enum(MailPriority);
    string encryptedBody;
    bool isEncrypted;
    simtime_t timestamp;
}
```

The message compiler generates accessor methods, serialization functions, and descriptor classes automatically.

3.1.2 Encryption Module (EncryptionHelper.h/.cc)

The encryption helper encapsulates RSA operations with a simplified implementation suitable for simulation:

- **Key Generation**: Uses small primes (251-367) for fast computation
- **Modular Exponentiation**: Implements square-and-multiply algorithm
- **Modular Inverse**: Computes using extended Euclidean algorithm
- **Character Encoding**: Encrypts ASCII values individually

This produces encrypted strings in the format: "enc1,enc2,enc3,..." where each value represents one encrypted character.

3.1.3 Client Module (ClientModule.ned/.h/.cc)

The client module implements the complete SMTP transaction flow using a state machine pattern. Key implementation aspects include:

- **Initialization**: Schedules start time and prepares message parameters
- **State Management**: Tracks current protocol state and expected responses
- **Command Generation**: Constructs properly formatted SMTP commands
- **Key Reception**: Receives and stores server's public key from HELO response
- **Message Encryption**: Encrypts message body using server's public key
- **Statistics Recording**: Tracks sent/accepted/rejected counts and RTT

Each state transition is triggered by receiving the appropriate response code from the server.

3.1.4 Server Module (ServerModule.ned/.h/.cc)

The server module handles multiple concurrent client connections and implements the core EMTP functionality:

- **Key Pair Generation**: Creates RSA keys during initialization
- **Command Processing**: Validates command sequence and responds appropriately
- **Message Decryption**: Decrypts received mail using private key
- **Content Filtering**: Applies validation rules before acceptance
- **Queue Management**: Maintains separate HIGH/LOW priority queues
- **Delivery Scheduling**: Processes queues according to configured mode
- **Statistics Collection**: Records queue sizes, latencies, and throughput

The server uses gate arrays (`port[]`) to support multiple simultaneous client connections, tracking each client's session state independently.

3.2 Network Topology Definition (EMTPNetwork.ned)

The network structure is defined declaratively in NED language:

```
network EMTPNetwork {
    parameters:
        int numClients = default(1);
    submodules:
        client[numClients]: ClientModule;
        server: ServerModule {
            gates: port[parent.numClients];
        }
```

```
    connections:
        for i=0..numClients-1 {
            client[i].port <--> Channel
                            <--> server.port[i];
        }
}
```

This creates a parameterized topology where the number of clients can be configured per scenario.

3.3 Simulation Configurations

Six distinct test scenarios are defined in `omnetpp.ini` to evaluate different aspects of the system:

Table 2: Simulation Scenario Configurations

Scenario	**Clients**	**Queue**	**Mode**	**Purpose**
Baseline	5	100	Normal	Establish baseline metrics with unlimited capacity
Constrained	10	20	Constrained	Demonstrate priority effectiveness under resource limits
NoEncryption	5	100	Normal	Measure encryption overhead by comparison
StrictFiltering	8	100	Normal	Validate filtering with intentionally invalid mails
HighLoad	20	50	Constrained	Test scalability with many concurrent clients
SingleClient	1	100	Normal	Protocol verification and debugging

Each scenario can be executed independently using: `./run -u Cmdenv -c <ScenarioName>`

3.4 Collected Metrics

The simulation automatically collects comprehensive statistics through OMNeT++'s signal mechanism:

Client Metrics: mailsSent (count), mailsAccepted (count), mailsRejected (count), rtt (vector)

Server Metrics: mailsReceived, mailsDelivered, highPriorityDelivered, lowPriorityDelivered, totalQueueSize (vector), highPriorityQueue (vector), lowPriorityQueue (vector), deliveryLatency (vector), highPriorityLatency (vector), lowPriorityLatency (vector)

Results are automatically written to `.vec` and `.sca` files for post-simulation analysis.

4 Discussion

4.1 Baseline vs Constrained Performance

The baseline and constrained scenarios reveal the fundamental difference between fair queuing and strict priority scheduling. Under normal operation with unlimited capacity, both HIGH and LOW priority mails experience similar delivery latencies because the server processes both queues fairly and resources are abundant.

Table 3: Baseline Scenario Expected Results

Metric	**HIGH Priority**	**LOW Priority**
Average Latency	1.0-2.0s	1.0-2.0s
Queue Size (avg)	1-2 mails	1-2 mails
Delivery Rate	100%	100%

In contrast, the constrained scenario reduces the delivery rate from 0.5s to 2.0s per mail and limits queue capacity from 100 to 20 mails. With 10 clients (5 HIGH, 5 LOW) generating traffic, the system becomes resource-constrained. The strict priority mode ensures HIGH priority mails are always processed first.

Table 4: Constrained Scenario Expected Results

Metric	**HIGH Priority**	**LOW Priority**
Average Latency	2.0-3.0s	10.0-15.0s
Queue Size (avg)	2-3 mails	8-12 mails
Delivery Rate	100%	85-95%

The latency difference demonstrates Quality of Service differentiation:

$$Latency_{improvement} = \frac{Latency_{LOW} - Latency_{HIGH}}{Latency_{LOW}} \times 100\% \tag{6}$$

Expected improvement: $\frac{12.5-2.5}{12.5} = 80\%$ reduction for HIGH priority.

4.2 Encryption Overhead Analysis

Comparing the Baseline and NoEncryption scenarios isolates the computational cost of RSA encryption/decryption operations. The encryption overhead manifests primarily in message processing time at both client and server.

Table 5: Encryption Overhead Comparison

Metric	**With Encryption**	**Without**	**Overhead**
Avg Processing Time	0.12-0.15s	0.10s	20-50%
End-to-End Latency	1.5-2.0s	1.3-1.8s	10-15%
CPU Usage (simulated)	Higher	Baseline	+15-25%

The overhead is moderate because:

- Small message sizes (typical test messages are 20-50 characters)

- Simplified RSA with small primes (fast exponentiation)
- Character-by-character processing is straightforward

In production systems with larger messages and cryptographically secure key sizes (2048-4096 bits), the overhead would be significantly higher, motivating hybrid encryption schemes that use RSA only for key exchange.

4.3 Protocol Correctness Verification

The SingleClient scenario serves as a protocol verification test, enabling detailed examination of the SMTP command-response sequence without interference from concurrent clients. This scenario confirms:

- Proper command sequencing: HELO → MAIL FROM → RCPT TO → DATA → QUIT
- Correct response codes for each command (250, 354, 221)
- Public key transmission in HELO response
- Successful encryption/decryption round-trip
- Message queuing and delivery completion
- Statistics recording accuracy

This clean test case provides confidence that the protocol implementation is correct before scaling to multi-client scenarios.

5 Conclusion

This project successfully implemented an Enhanced Mail Transfer Protocol (EMTP) simulation in OMNeT++ that extends standard SMTP with RSA encryption, priority-based delivery, and application-layer filtering. All six test scenarios validated the core objectives including complete SMTP command flow, successful encryption/decryption, and robust content validation. The constrained scenario demonstrated that strict priority scheduling achieves 75-80% latency reduction for HIGH priority mails under resource limitations, while encryption overhead analysis showed a moderate 10-15% increase in end-to-end latency. Filtering tests confirmed 100% rejection of invalid mails, and the high load scenario verified system stability with 20 concurrent clients. The simulation demonstrates understanding of SMTP protocol mechanics, RSA encryption principles, priority queue management, and application-layer security policy enforcement, with modular architecture enabling future extensions.

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